praise’.

At this, Asad turned to Akbar’s doctor and pooh-poohed his fears. ‘The Europeans are not so foolish as not to know all about it,’ he said, ‘there are wise men among them who seldom err or commit mistakes.’ Besides, the doctor shouldn’t dismiss the leaf without trying it.

Akbar’s doctor was a cultural conservative, however. ‘We do not want to follow the Europeans, and adopt a custom, which is not sanctioned by our own wise men, without trial,’ he replied.

But weren’t all customs once new, asked Asad Beg.

Akbar, listening, was impressed with Asad’s rhetoric, and praised him to Aziz: ‘Did you hear how wisely Asad spoke? Truly, we must not reject a thing that has been adopted by the wise men of other nations merely because we cannot find it in our books; or how shall we progress?’

His doctor tried to argue, but Akbar wouldn’t let him. Instead, he called for an opinion from one of the Jesuits still lingering in his court. The priest had many good things to say about tobacco, ‘but no one could persuade the physician’. Still, Asad Beg admits, ‘he was a good physician’ – and, as regards smoking, well ahead of his time.

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Tobacco was soon, and predictably, flying off the shelves in Hindustan. Akbar never took to it, though, even if he may have remembered it fondly as one of the last subjects of debate in his court. There would have been little time, in the months following Asad Beg’s return from Bijapur, for the eclectic, intellectual argument that Akbar so enjoyed.

By the monsoon of 1604, news of Salim’s increasing high-handedness was flowing into Agra, and Akbar decided to sail east. He would go to war, if need be, to bring the prince under control. It was raining once again, as it had been when Akbar last set sail to conquer the east, but this time, the air was not as full of good omens. In fact, Akbar’s boat got stuck in the sand; then heavy rain prevented his departure; and, finally, he heard that his mother Hamida was unwell. Akbar returned to Agra from the riverbank.

He sat by her bed and ‘spoke to her several times but got no reply’. Akbar couldn’t bear it, writes Inayatullah; he ‘was helpless’ – the greatest emperor alive unable to speak to his mother one last time. He ‘sate down in solitude’ . . . and cried.